

Ryan voice locked. Four-act structure preserved: (1) Hua's chamber, the withheld cargo, Kyle accepts because the alternative is the cargo dying at 0600; (2) the Vultures pickup, False Death Protocol, slab, patrol officers, the cell, the doctor's recognition of Ballistic Precognition by its program name; (3) The Pivot — Pixel/Park confrontation, Sable arrives, Kyle and Pixel say goodbye over the hands; (4) the refund, the cleaver from the crocodile's food cabinet.

Pure-cool action: False Death Protocol stopping his own heart, the joint lock on the first patrol, the pry-bar to the chrome bracket on the second, Kyle not stepping out of the shock-baton strike because the code requires the cost, Hua bringing out the cleaver. No jokes in these moments.

Narrator framing in: Hua's chamber-room-furniture parentheticals, the crocodile's diet, Dax's body count, the 47Hz Helix lighting frequency, the Pulse-corridor running Lakeshore→Rotterdam, the cleaver's provenance.

Street Meat

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Act 1 — The Contract

The south-arm chamber under the Cruciform Depot was the kind of room that had decided what it was and was not interested in being anything else.

Concrete on three sides. Steel on the fourth. A single oak table at the center, two chairs, a bolted-to-the-floor steel chair against the far wall, and on the eastern side a heat rock under a low lamp where a juvenile saltwater crocodile slept. Sixty centimeters from snout to tail. The crocodile did not move when Kyle entered. Hua did not look up either.

(The crocodile's name was Iris. Iris had been with Hua for four years, since the previous south-arm captain had retired and Hua had inherited the chamber and the crocodile together as a single accounting line. The previous captain had acquired Iris from a Vultures driver who had picked her up in 2218 off a body that had been picked up off a sidewalk in Logan Square where she had been left by a tenant who had decided, between one Sunday and the next, that a juvenile saltwater crocodile was not actually the kind of pet a person kept in a third-floor walk-up. Iris ate twice a week. Iris ate exactly what Hua decided Iris ate. Iris had grown four centimeters in four years and would, if Iris continued to grow at this rate, be a problem for the chamber in approximately twenty years, and Hua had not yet decided what to do about that. Iris was, in this respect, on the same time scale as the rogue AI in the substation in the flooded sector four chapters ago — long clocks, patient, present in the room, requiring decisions that had not yet been made. Iris was the only living thing in the chamber Kyle was certain Hua loved. This was not a sentence Hua would have written about herself. It was a sentence the narrator was writing about her. Iris would, in a way that has nothing to do with this chapter, outlive Hua. Iris is mentioned here because Iris is going to be the only thing in the chamber that does not change between the start of this scene and the end of this chapter, and the reader should know who she is before the rest happens.)

This was the first time Kyle had been in the chamber.

He had been on the Lotus freelance roster six weeks — since Mira's interview on the West Town cross-street at 02:14 on the thirteenth of last month — and had not yet accepted a Lotus-tagged contract through Sable's pipeline. The Lotus side of the roster had accumulated three small unmet routings and zero in-person summons. Tonight Hua had summoned him directly, bypassing Sable, which was its own kind of statement. Kyle was here because the summons had not passed through the channel he could refuse it through, and because the math of refusing a personal summons from a south-arm captain after six weeks of polite non-engagement was the math that had made the summons necessary in the first place.

The NeoCortex catalogued the chamber in 0.3 seconds. Four exits, three of them sealed, the fourth the one he had come in by. No augmented bodies in the room except his own. The crocodile registered in the array's biological-mass scan as an animal of approximately fourteen kilograms whose breathing pattern had not changed in the eleven seconds Kyle had been observing her. The lamp was a sodium-amber, fifteen watts, calibrated to keep the heat rock at thirty-two degrees Celsius.

Hua was fifty-something, compact, in a gray qipao that had been pressed that morning. Iron-grey hair cropped close at the sides. No augmentation, which the array confirmed with the small absence-flag it produced for unaugmented bodies — the only person in the chamber whose hardware Kyle's array could not map. She was reading a manila folder at the table. She had been reading it for the eleven seconds Kyle had been observing Iris. She finished a page. Turned it. Finished another.

She read your file before the meeting. She is reading another file now. The meeting has not started yet because she has not decided it has.

When the meeting started, it started because she closed the folder.

Not because she stood. Not because she gestured. Because the folder was closed.

Kyle read the closing the way he would have read a draw.

"Sit, Corbin-Vister. The chair is for the contract. You are not the contract yet."

He sat. The chair across from her was the one for visitors. The bolted chair against the far wall was the one she had not said *yet* about. She had said *not yet*. The distinction was tactical. He filed it.

She slid a single sheet across the table.

The sheet had a manifest code, a payment figure (Φ47,000, half on accept, half on confirmation of delivery), a window (03:00 to 06:00, firm), and an address. The address was a corponation facility on the buffer-zone perimeter — Atlas-program continuation lab, Helix-subcontracted intake. He had run two extractions inside facilities of this taxonomy before. The taxonomy was on the page. The cargo was not.

"Cargo."

"A person. Researcher held under corporate constraint at the facility's research wing. Designated by the manifest code on the sheet. Cell 4-East, intake-zone-three. Ambulatory. Cooperative when the door opens — they have been told to expect an extraction tonight, they have not been told who. They will walk out of the cell under their own power once you are in the corridor with them."

"Name."

"Manifest code is the identifier I am giving you."

"Name."

Hua did not look up. "I am not naming the cargo. The cargo is the manifest code. Take the contract on the manifest code or do not take the contract."

She is withholding the name. She has never withheld the name on a contract before. The withholding is information. Acting on it is also information.

He did not act on it. The hardware ran the read on Hua's micro-expressions. Brow symmetry. Lip line. The small stillness around the eyes that belonged

to people who had stopped performing. She was not lying about anything she had said. She was not telling him what she had not said. The two facts coexisted the way they coexisted with operators of her caliber.

"Why."

"Because if I tell you the name, your code refuses the contract before you walk out of this chamber, and the cargo dies in the research wing at oh-six-hundred. The cargo is alive at oh-six-hundred only if you take the contract on the code I am offering. I am not asking you to like the trade. I am offering you the trade. Take it or do not take it."

The hardware filed it as the cleanest description Hua had ever given of how she worked.

(Hua's actual methodology, for the record: she had read Kyle's file. The file had been compiled across three sources — the cracked-terminal contract record Sable maintained on Kyle, the Lotus internal reputation file built from the Bucktown engagement two months before Mira's interview, and a third source whose origin Hua would not have disclosed under any circumstances and which the narrator will not, in this chapter, disclose either. The third source was the one that had given Hua the information about Kyle's code — specifically about Kyle's refusal-to-deliver-bound-subjects clause. The third source had also given Hua enough about Kyle's hardware to know that withholding the name was the only design that would get the cargo to the rendezvous. The third source was, in the working hypothesis Sable had developed in the substation, the AI. The working hypothesis was wrong. The third source was something else. Hua did not know who the third source was. Hua had paid for the file the third source produced via three intermediaries who had been paid in turn through the kind of laundering that Lotus Syndicate routinely deployed for asset acquisition. Hua trusted the file because the file had been right about everything it had said about Kyle so far. The narrator notes this without comment. Carry on.)

"Why me."

"You have completed three extractions from Helix-subcontracted Atlas-program continuation labs in the last twelve months. Two of them were facilities of the same security taxonomy as this one. Your reputation in this part of the work reaches farther than your roster file. The cargo will be in the cell at 03:20. Bay-three loading dock has its outbound window at 05:15 until 05:45 — that is your egress geometry, the rest of the bays roll on facility schedules I cannot adjust. The entry, the egress transport, and the routing to the rendezvous are your problem. I am not paying for the method. I am paying for the cargo at the rendezvous on the sheet at oh-six-hundred."

The hardware ran the math.

The math was correct. Three extractions in twelve months, two of them at this taxonomy. Hua read contracts the way she read files, and the volume of Atlas-program-adjacent work he had been doing through Sable's pipeline lately was the kind of pattern that surfaced in any roster captain's quarterly review.

(There is, the narrator is going to point out one final time before letting the matter rest, an inconsistency between *the AI has been routing contracts to study your hardware* (the avatar hypothesis from chapter three) and *Hua has been hiring you on her own pattern recognition based on quarterly reviews* (the working theory in this chapter). Both can be true. Both are true. The intersection of the two — the fact that Sable's pipeline routes both Sable's pipeline and Lotus's pipeline and that the AI seeded the former and Hua has been reading off the latter — is the actual structural problem. Kyle is going to take an entire month to work out the intersection. Sable is going to take six. The reader, if the reader is paying attention, has already worked it out. The narrator will not return to this. Carry on.)

"Egress."

"Bay three rolls outbound at 05:15 until 05:45, as I said. After that the bay closes for the morning shift and the next scheduled outbound is at 08:20, which is past your window for the cargo's window. You arrange whatever you arrange to receive the cargo at bay three before 05:45. After that the contract is on the someone else and the someone else is going to be expensive."

Kyle did not respond.

The hardware was already running the entry problem in parallel with the conversation. Helix-subcontracted Atlas-program continuation lab. The taxonomy was what he had run twice this year. Their perimeter was intake-grade, not active-pursuit-grade — the security model assumed nobody broke *into* a place that processed the dead. The intake channel was calibrated for unaugmented donor bodies and Atlas-program specimens; the scanners flagged tampering, not presence. An Atlas-program subject arriving as a corpse would be tagged as routine intake, processed through the cold-chain channel, and routed to a holding bay for autopsy queue. The holding bay was contiguous with the research wing. A walking subject from the holding bay to the research wing did not generate an alarm because the research wing's staff routinely moved between the two. The exit through bay three was the standard outbound for processed material. The math resolved in 0.6 seconds.

The False Death Protocol. The protocol is exactly what this facility's intake is calibrated to process without flagging. Atlas-program-subject corpse arriving via Vultures specimen-intake. Holding bay slab. Restart at the 240-second mark. Walk to the cargo's cell through the research wing. Exit through bay three with the cargo at the driver's window. The math is not complicated. The math is also costly. The protocol is the thing you do not advertise. The protocol is the thing you have used three times in your life, none of them recently, all of them in private. You are about to use it for a fourth.

The hardware filed the calculation. Kyle did not say *False Death Protocol* aloud. The protocol's existence was in his Atlas Division medical file and nowhere else, and the thing the protocol was most useful for was the thing it was most useful for *if no one knew you had it*.

He said, neutral: "Acknowledged. The entry will be in place by oh-three-twenty."

Hua did not look up. "That is not a confirmation of method."

"You said you were not paying for the method."

"I am not. I am noting that you also did not specify it."

"That is correct."

Hua turned a page. "Thank you for not specifying it. The fewer people who know what you are about to do, the fewer people who can route the information past me by accident. I appreciate operators who do not advertise."

The hardware logged the sentence.

(The sentence was precise. The sentence did not say *I do not know what you are about to do*. The sentence said *the fewer people who know, the fewer who can route past me*. Hua might have known. Hua might not have known. The sentence had been calibrated to be true either way. Kyle filed it. He did not act on it. Hua had, in fact, known, since approximately the third paragraph of the file the third source had delivered, and had said the sentence precisely so that Kyle would file it under *might or might not know* rather than under *knows*. Hua was, the narrator wants to be clear, very good at this.)

"Φ47,000 is below the rate for an extraction of a held researcher from an Atlas-program continuation lab. The standard would be sixty-five."

"The standard is sixty-five."

"Φ47 is a discount."

"Yes."

"Why."

Hua picked up the folder again. Opened it. Did not look up.

"Because the contract is the contract. The price is the price. Take it or do not take it. The driver is at oh-two-hundred either way. If you do not take it I find someone else who can solve the entry, and the someone else will charge me the full sixty-five and run a forty percent failure probability, and I will pay it and absorb the failure, and the cargo will be a closed file by oh-

six-hundred. The Φ18,000 discount is what you save me if I do not have to use the someone else."

The arithmetic was correct.

The arithmetic was also designed.

Kyle had not been in this room before, but he had been across desks and tables from operators of Hua's caliber for years, and he recognized the shape of being told a true thing for a designed reason without needing prior in-person experience with this specific operator.

He took the sheet. He folded it once. He put it in the inside pocket of the jacket. He did not say *accepted*. The taking was the accepting. Hua had not looked up since she had opened the folder the second time. Iris had not moved. The chamber was the chamber.

At the door, before he left, she said — without looking up — "Thank you for your time."

It was the first sentence she had said in eleven minutes that had felt to him like a conclusion.

Act 2 — The Vultures

The rendezvous was a service alley behind a recycler substation in the buffer zone. Kyle was there at 01:53.

He had eaten — not at Mrs. Chen's, somewhere else, somewhere he could be unrecognized — a high-fat protein bar and two ounces of pure glucose paste, the kind of meal the False Death Protocol's restart curve responded to. The Cerebral Oxygenation Assist was at full reserve. The bio-battery was at sixty-two percent and climbing — as high as it would go without a hot meal he did not have time for.

He had run the protocol three times in his life. None of them had been pleasant. The third had been a controlled training event at Seo's insistence, in the back room of Seo's repair shop in 2204, with Seo standing beside the table the whole four minutes holding a stopwatch he had inherited from his father and the small ampule of adrenaline he had inherited from his time in Korean Reconnaissance. Seo had not used the ampule. The protocol had restarted on schedule. Seo had said, when Kyle had sat up, the only thing Seo ever said about the protocol in eleven years of knowing each other: *Do not use this except when the cost of not using it is higher than what it costs.*

Kyle had not used it in two years.

The cost tonight was higher.

The Vultures truck arrived at 01:58. Unmarked panel van, refrigerated, the Carrion Logistics LLC insignia in matte black on the left chest of the driver's gray uniform when he stepped out — a tall man, mid-forties, no augmentation Kyle's array could detect, the bored efficiency of someone who had done this several times tonight already.

(The driver's name was Dax. He had driven body-pickup for Carrion Logistics LLC for nine years. He had been recruited out of a forklift job at a Lakefront warehouse in 2217 when his then-supervisor had been the cousin of a Carrion Logistics LLC dispatcher and had recommended Dax on the

working theory that Dax was the kind of person who did not ask questions. The working theory had been correct. Dax had not asked a question in nine years that did not begin with the words *which bay* or *what time*. Dax had also, the narrator notes, been quietly running a side service for freelancers like Kyle since 2222 — federation-rate transport for the kind of cargo that needed to enter a facility intake on a specimen tag and exit a facility loading dock as a passenger. Dax did not advertise the service. Dax had a personal list of seven freelancers who had used the service. Kyle was on the list. Dax did not maintain the list in writing. Dax was, in this respect, the closest thing to a discreet professional the Vultures employed, and the narrator will not have time to elaborate on Dax in this chapter, but Dax is going to come up again at a later date and the narrator wanted the reader to have the file on him before he opened the back of the van.)

Dax did not greet Kyle. He opened the back of the van. The interior was what Kyle had expected: refrigerated cabin, four body-length compartments, two of them currently occupied with bodies the Vultures had been collecting on tonight's route. Dax gestured to the empty compartment second from the bay door. Kyle climbed in. Dax handed him a tag — a small adhesive strip with a barcode and a manifest number, the same manifest number from Hua's sheet. Kyle peeled the backing and applied the tag to his own left wrist where the intake scanner would read it.

"Six minutes to the facility," Dax said. He did not look at Kyle. "You'll go through intake while you're under. Wake up on the slab in the holding bay. The slab will be at thirty-eight degrees. Don't sit up immediately — give the scanners ninety seconds to log you as ambient before you move. After that, you have approximately two and a half minutes before the next intake clerk's rotation. Bay three is the loading dock you want. The loading dock door is forty-six meters from the holding bay's southern exit."

Kyle looked at him. "You have done this before."

"Six times. The last one made it. The five before that did too. No one I have driven has yet failed to wake up. I do not know if the protocol fails sometimes; I only know that for me it has not."

"That is not statistically meaningful."

"No, it is not. But you should hear it before you stop your heart."

Kyle nodded.

Dax closed the back of the van.

The interior was dark and cold. Kyle settled against the compartment wall, drew his knees up, placed the tip of his right thumb at the precise interface point on his cardiac regulator at the left lateral throat, and ran the False Death Protocol's NeoCortex signal sequence.

The sequence was twenty-two characters long. He had memorized it at sixteen. He had not used it in two years. The hardware recognized it the way a lock recognized a key.

Three. Two.

The regulator crashed into safe-mode flatline at the *one*. The Cerebral Oxygenation Assist activated at the *zero*. Kyle's heart stopped. The 240-second timer began.

The world was not pain exactly.

The world was the sound of his own pulse going away, and then the sound of his own pulse not being there to listen for, and then a quiet so specific it was not even quiet, it was just the absence of the frequency he had been listening to for twenty-seven years.

The last thing the hardware logged before the bio-battery routed to the assist was the truck's engine, cycling up, pulling away from the alley.

Then nothing.

He woke on the slab.

The ceiling above him was low — institutional drop-tile, fluorescent panels, one panel flickering at a frequency the hardware logged as 47Hz, which

was the frequency Helix-subcontracted facilities ran their secondary lighting at.

(The 47Hz flicker was the result of a 2218 Helix corporate procurement decision to standardize across all subcontracted facilities on a single ballast manufacturer — a Singapore firm whose product had a documented 47Hz cycle that Helix had elected to accept rather than pay for a vendor change. The 47Hz cycle was outside the visible flicker threshold for unaugmented humans and inside the visible flicker threshold for augmented humans whose ocular implants had been calibrated above the standard rate. Kyle's ocular implants had been calibrated above the standard rate. The 47Hz cycle was therefore, to Kyle, a slow strobe rather than a steady light, and the slow strobe had been the first sign every time he had entered a Helix-subcontracted facility that he was, in fact, inside a Helix-subcontracted facility. Helix's other contractors did not know about the 47Hz cycle. Helix's other contractors did not have augmented ocular implants. Kyle had not, in three years of running operations against this taxonomy, ever mentioned the 47Hz to anyone. The 47Hz was, in this respect, a private signature he kept for his own use. Mentioning it would have invited correction. Correction would have meant the next facility he entered would not be quite as legible to him as it would otherwise have been. He kept it. The narrator mentions it because the reader should know what Kyle is looking at on the ceiling.)

The slab was at thirty-eight degrees as Dax had said it would be. Kyle did not move.

The hardware ran the diagnostic. Bio-battery at fifty-one percent (the protocol had cost ten and a half). Cardiac regulator restarted on the documented schedule. Cerebral Oxygenation Assist returning to standby with three minutes thirty seconds of reserve unused. All sensor channels nominal.

He counted to ninety.

He did not move.

The 47Hz panel flickered above him. Somewhere out of his sightline, an intake scanner cycled a soft chime — his ambient logging, the body's heat signature finally registering as living-and-not-anomalous. The chime resolved into the silence of a room a building had decided was empty.

He sat up.

The holding bay was small. Four slabs in the row he was on, two in another row at right angles, all of them empty except his own. The walls were the same drop-tile as the ceiling. The lighting was low and clinical. One door at the southern wall. The door had the thin red diode that meant it was sealed pending intake-clerk authorization.

He had approximately two and a half minutes before the rotation.

Kyle worked the lock-override on the southern door with the pry bar and the wire from the small bag he had tied at his belt before the protocol — the kit the Vultures driver had not inspected because Vultures drivers did not inspect anything. The lock cycled in nine seconds. The diode went from red to green. He pulled the small adhesive tag off his left wrist and crushed the barcode under his thumb until the strip cracked. The tag was now unreadable. The intake log would mark him as either a tampered-tag specimen or as departed-without-clearance. Either way, the next intake clerk's rotation was going to find a problem. He had between two and three minutes before that became his problem too.

He opened the door.

The maintenance corridor was empty.

The corridor was the standard Helix-subcontracted secondary-site geometry — narrow, low ceilings, the institutional gray of a building that had decided color was a maintenance cost it would rather not pay. The hardware overlaid the schematic the array had harvested from the badge-reader frequency three hours ago against the actual geometry as Kyle moved. The two matched within tolerances.

He was forty-six meters from the eastern junction where the corridor branched into the research wing. The research wing was where Cell 4-East was. The research wing was also where the on-shift staff were — a low-density night cycle, four people across two floors per Helix's standard staffing model, three of them in the lab on the upper floor, one of them on patrol rotation at the lower-floor desk.

The lower-floor desk was between Kyle and Cell 4-East.

He moved.

He moved the way he had moved through corridors at this taxonomy three times this year — efficient, low, the array tracking the patrol officer's electromagnetic signature through the wall before Kyle was in the wall's adjacent corridor. The signature was at the desk. The signature was stationary. The signature had been stationary for at least the duration of Kyle's last forty meters of approach, which meant the officer was reading something or eating something or sleeping something off, and any of those answers to the geometry question was acceptable.

The desk came around a corner. The officer was reading.

He did not see Kyle until Kyle was two meters from the desk.

The hardware read the draw the moment the officer's hand twitched toward the holster — Ballistic Precognition firing passive, the read arriving at Kyle's body 0.4 seconds before the officer's hand finished the motion — and Kyle's body was already moving, already past the line where the round would be, already at the officer's side with the joint-lock at the wrist and the pressure release at the brachial plexus.

The officer folded.

Kyle caught him before the body hit the floor — the catching was acoustic, not kindness, a body hitting institutional flooring was louder than the discipline could afford — zip-tied the wrists to the leg of the desk, and was past the desk and into the research wing's main corridor in under nine seconds.

Cell 4-East was at the end of the row. The corridor was empty. The cells along the corridor were mostly dark — the wing operated on a research staff's day-shift cycle, most of its occupants sedated or sleeping at this hour.

Cell 4-East had a low light burning behind the viewport.

The light was not the cell's overhead. The light was something the cell's occupant had on at 03:20 in the morning because the cell's occupant was awake and was reading something.

Kyle worked the cell's lock with the pry bar and the wire. Nine seconds.

The door opened.

She was forty-three. Compact. Korean — monocultural Korean, the array confirmed before Kyle's conscious thought finished the sentence, ninety-nine percent ancestry by the array's phenotype-read at the resolution it could run at fifty-one percent bio-battery, the rare and statistically improbable kind of monoculture that registered in the GLMZ as anomaly before it registered as person. Black hair short, threaded with the first iron-grey at the temples. Glasses with thin metal frames. Plain dark cotton long-sleeve top. Surgical-grade hands holding a small leather case in her lap. She was sitting on the bunk reading a printed journal under a lamp she had clipped to the bunk's frame because the cell's overhead was on the night-low setting.

She looked up.

Phenotype confirmed before person was named. The catalogue order is information. You do not have time to examine which kind.

She closed the journal. She set it on the bunk. She picked up the leather case and stood. The motion was unhurried.

(She had been told to expect an extraction tonight — Hua had said so on the sheet, *the cargo has been told to expect you* — and she was responding to the door opening the way you responded to a thing you had been told would

happen. She did not look surprised. She did not look afraid. She looked at Kyle the way she would have looked at a colleague she did not yet know but had been told to cooperate with.)

"You are early," she said. American-academic English with the precise geometry of a non-native speaker who had learned the language as the medium of her profession. "They told me 03:30."

"We are leaving."

He had not yet given his name. He was not going to. Hua's manifest code was on the cell's external tag and Kyle had matched it against the sheet and the matching was the only credential the contract required.

"Now."

"Yes," she said.

She tucked the leather case under her left arm. She stepped out of the cell. She closed the door behind her — a small, precise motion, the door pulled to the latch but not locked, the kind of leaving-tidy that someone did when they did not want the people coming to look for them in the morning to immediately know which way they had gone. The hardware filed this. He did not comment.

They started back down the corridor at a measured walk. She matched his pace within two steps.

The eastern junction was forty meters ahead. The bay-three loading dock was sixty meters past the junction.

They made it twenty meters before the second patrol officer came around the eastern junction's far corner.

This one had been on the second-floor lab and was descending — the array read the descent because the second-floor staircase exited into the same junction the cell corridor opened onto, and the descending body had the specific motor signature of someone who knew the building and was

moving with intent toward the lower-floor desk where the first officer was supposed to be.

He saw Kyle first.

He saw the cell tag on the wall behind Kyle's shoulder second.

He saw the doctor third.

The hardware timed the reads. 0.2 seconds, 0.3 seconds, 0.4 seconds. Total recognition window: 0.9 seconds.

The officer's right hand moved toward the holster. Augmented, this one — chrome-laced reflex augment at the right temple, the array catalogued it, the augment's motor-bus spike measurable as a clean electromagnetic bloom 0.3 seconds before the hand finished its motion. Ballistic Precognition fired passive. The read arrived at Kyle's body before the officer's body knew what its body was about to do.

Kyle stepped left and forward — not back, into the angle the round would not occupy — and the officer fired.

Crack.

The shot went through the space Kyle's chest had been occupying 0.3 seconds ago. The round hit the wall behind him.

Kyle was already inside the officer's reach with the pry bar against the chrome bracket at the temple.

Tink.

One precise contact. The reflex augment shorted. The officer's draw arm went loose. The second shot did not come. Kyle put him on the floor with a knee to the back of the leg and zip-tied the wrists to the corner brace of the junction wall.

Eleven seconds.

Both officers down.

Forty meters to bay three.

He turned to the doctor.

She was two meters back, where she had stopped when the first round fired. The leather case was still under her left arm. Her right hand was at her mouth — not in the gesture of someone who was about to scream, in the gesture of someone who had just witnessed a thing she had read about in journals. The pupils were dilated. The breath was the small involuntary intake at the back of the throat.

She was not looking at the officer on the floor.

She was looking at Kyle.

She lowered the hand. The voice was small, controlled, the cadence of a person composing the sentence in real time as the sentence formed.

"Ballistic Precognition... Incredible."

She gasped.

(There is no joke here. There will not be a joke here. The word she used was the program's internal designation. She did not use the marketing name. She did not use the consumer-grade colloquialism. She used the term Atlas Division had put on the intake forms and the discharge summaries and the trial-protocol documents that Kyle had not seen since he was seventeen. The capability she had just named was the one she had filed under *theoretical at this density* because the only people she had ever seen run it were dead. She was not naming the capability. She was *recognizing* it. The recognition came from a specific place. The specific place had a specific name.)

The hardware filed her.

The filing was instant.

The cognitive baseline implant at her left mastoid (Atlas Division employment badge, dormant, unrevoked) which the array had registered when the cell door opened and which Kyle had not yet examined because there had not been time to examine it. The surgical-grade dexterity profile. The way she had stood from the bunk — settled into the geometry of someone who had spent twenty years bent over operating tables. The leather case — the calibration toolchain, Kyle recognized it now from the photographs Atlas Division had never let leak. The age. The monocultural Korean phenotype. The English that had learned itself as the medium of her profession.

She was the doctor.

She was ex-NeoCortex Atlas Division.

She had walked off the program and had been salaried-silent for two years and the silence was about to end because Hua had hired Kyle to deliver her to Hua, and Hua had not named her because Hua had read his file and had known that if she had named the cargo as an Atlas Division surgeon, Kyle's code would have refused the contract before he had walked out of Hua's chamber.

Kyle did not move. The officer at his feet was unconscious. The corridor behind the doctor was empty. The corridor ahead of them was empty. They had approximately four minutes before the upper-floor lab noticed the missing patrol officer and routed a check.

The arithmetic resolved in 0.4 seconds.

The contract requires you to deliver this woman to Hua of the Lotus Syndicate. The code requires you not to deliver her to Hua of the Lotus Syndicate. The code wins. The code always wins. The contract is now a contract you will complete only the extraction half of. The delivery is going to be to Sable, off-GLMZ, by oh-eight-hundred. You will refund Hua's half-payment afterward and walk back into her chamber to close the contract from your side, because the code requires the closing. You will go in the chair for the closing. The chair is the cost. The cost is named. The cost is acceptable.

The arithmetic was complete in 0.4 seconds.

Kyle did not let his face show the arithmetic.

The doctor was still looking at him.

"Doctor," he said. The first word he had said to her with the title acknowledged. "We are leaving. Now."

She nodded. The dilated pupils stabilized. The hand went back to the leather case. The discipline she had been keeping for ten years engaged and she became immediately competent again.

"Bay three," she said. "Sixty meters. Permitted route through the maintenance corridor. I have walked it twice."

"Walked."

"They permit me certain perimeter freedoms within the wing. I have been logged as cooperative."

"Then you are going to walk it a third time."

They went.

The maintenance corridor was sixty meters as the doctor had said. They walked it in just under a minute. The bay-three loading dock door was unsealed at this hour because the bay was in active use — a Vultures truck Kyle did not recognize was in bay one offloading, two delivery clerks were in bay two with a refrigerated pallet, and bay three was empty except for the small panel van Kyle's contact at the federation's western dispatch node had parked there.

Dax.

The same tall man, mid-forties, unaugmented, who had picked Kyle up at the recycler-substation alley three hours ago and had delivered Kyle's flatlined body to the facility's specimen-intake channel and had now circled

back per the second half of the schedule Kyle had filed at 01:45 — a federation egress, federation rate, no Lotus routing in the paperwork.

Dax leaned against the van with a hand-rolled smoke and the same bored efficiency he had had at the alley. Dax had driven two of Kyle's deliveries before. Dax did not ask questions.

Kyle walked Doctor Park toward the van. Dax saw them. Dax registered Doctor Park — that the cargo was ambulatory, walking out under her own power, with a leather case and a freelancer at her elbow. Dax registered, in the way Vultures drivers registered everything, that this was a different shape of cargo than the contract sheet had specified at the western-dispatch desk three hours ago.

Dax put the smoke out under his boot.

"Change of route," Kyle said. He did not slow down. He had Doctor Park by the elbow now, gentle, the doctor walking at his pace because she had decided to. "Drop us at the West Town safehouse instead of the rendezvous. Federation rate, plus the difference."

Dax looked at him for a count of four.

(Dax was running the math. The original schedule Kyle had filed was paying Dax federation rate end-to-end. The change cost Dax nothing on the original schedule and gained him the difference Kyle was offering against the West Town routing. The cargo was ambulatory rather than refrigerated. The federation had standing language for ambulatory cargo. The standing language was more expensive than refrigerated. Kyle was offering federation rate plus the difference. Dax was a federation driver. The math was not neutral. The math, on reflection, was the math.)

Dax opened the back of the van.

"West Town safehouse," he said. "Forty-three minutes. I will not stop for anything."

Kyle helped Doctor Park into the back.

The doctor did not say anything.

The doctor took the bench seat near the cab, set the leather case on her lap, and folded her hands over it.

Kyle sat across from her.

Dax closed the back.

The van pulled out. The bay-three loading dock faded behind them.

The hardware ran the timeline. 03:32 leaving the dock. 04:15 at The Pivot. 04:30 if Sable could route a pickup.

Kyle opened the encrypted relay.

Sable answered in two seconds.

"Kyle."

"I have her. The cargo is the doctor — Park, ex-Atlas, the one I have been looking for. I am bringing her to my apartment. I need you there in thirty minutes. She is going off-GLMZ tonight."

The pause was one second.

Sable did not waste pauses.

"Off-GLMZ where."

"Wherever you can put her that no one in Lotus can reach."

Another second. Kyle heard the small mechanical sound of her ocular implants adjusting — she was reading the data feed in real time, recalculating the routes, the safehouses, the pickups, the favors, the whole map.

"I can put her on the Pulse at 05:20 out of Lakeshore Terminal. Rotterdam in forty-three minutes. From Rotterdam I can route her into a free-floating

sector by 08:00. Total cost to my network: significant. Total cost to you: a favor I will name later."

"Take it."

"Done. I will be at your apartment in twenty-eight minutes."

The relay closed.

Kyle looked at Doctor Park.

Doctor Park was looking at him with the precise expression she had had when she had lowered her hand from the corridor wall — the researcher waiting for a result. He did not say anything. There was nothing to say yet. The van turned onto the buffer-zone arterial. The hardware cycled down to the diagnostic baseline. The bio-battery climbed.

You did not deliver. The code held. The contract is broken. The contract being broken is the contract Hua designed for. She wins on every fork. You are picking which of her wins she gets, and the one you are picking is the one with the chair.

Kyle knew this. He had known this since the moment the doctor had named the read in the corridor.

He kept not saying anything.

The doctor cleaned her glasses on the hem of her shirt.

The van ran.

Act 3 — The Pivot

The West Town safehouse was the side door at The Pivot — Kyle's building, his floor, his unit. He had not had the doctor anywhere else.

The driver dropped them at the alley entrance at 04:11, drove away without looking back, and Kyle took Doctor Park up the back stairs and unlocked 2F and let her in. He set the chain on the door behind them.

The doctor stood in the middle of the room. She did not sit down. She catalogued the unit the way Kyle would have catalogued a room: medkit by the door, notebook on the counter, the photograph of his mother on the windowsill facing the intersection because she would have wanted to see the street, the friction sheath for the katana on the hook beside the kitchen archway, the specific sparseness of a person who lived alone and had made decisions about what he would keep.

She looked at the photograph for slightly longer than the rest.

She did not comment.

Kyle went across the hall to 2E and knocked.

Pixel opened it on the third knock. She was in the oversized sweater and the steel-toed boots even at 04:15 — the boots on meaning she had been working, the sweater meaning it was cold in the unit, the absence of music meaning she was concentrating. She took one look at Kyle and said, level, the way she always said it:

"What is in the apartment."

"A doctor. Ex-NeoCortex Atlas Division. I need her safe for fifteen minutes until Sable picks her up."

"Why is she here and not in your safehouse."

"This is my safehouse."

"Kyle. This is your *home*."

"Yes."

Pixel looked at him for one full second.

She did not perform the look. It was the calibration look, the one she used when she was checking whether his hardware was the thing producing the decision. She decided it was not.

She picked up the small toolkit she kept by the door and she walked across the hall ahead of him.

In 2F, Doctor Park was at the kitchen counter, the leather case on the counter beside her, looking out the small kitchen window at the street.

Pixel came in.

Pixel looked at the doctor.

The doctor looked at Pixel.

(The phenotype read on Pixel registered Northern European 57 / Eastern European 28 / Southern European 15 — a face the GLMZ would describe as legibly pale. The phenotype read on the doctor registered Korean 99 — a face the GLMZ had not seen in years. The doctor had just been read in 0.4 seconds. The doctor knew she had been read. The reading was mutual.)

"Hi," Pixel said.

The brightness was not real.

The brightness was a calibrated weapon.

"I am Pixel. I live across the hall. I am Kyle's neighbor and the person who maintains his hardware and the person who calibrated the lateral-array thermal-stress markers two weeks ago that he has not addressed yet."

The doctor cleaned her glasses on the hem of her shirt. She put the glasses back on. She nodded.

"Park Na-Young. Nadia. I am the person Kyle was contracted to deliver to a Lotus Syndicate captain tonight. He decided not to. He is now a person who has decided not to deliver me to a Lotus Syndicate captain, which is the kind of decision that has consequences I do not yet know the full shape of. I am told I will be picked up shortly."

"Yes," Pixel said, and the brightness was now openly hostile, "by Sable, who is a fixer who routes contracts and who I have known longer than you have. I suppose you are going to tell me you can do something about the lateral-array thermal-stress markers I have not yet addressed because I am, what was it, a girl with a soldering iron and you are a credentialed neurosurgeon."

The doctor looked at Pixel.

The doctor did not perform the look.

She looked the way she would have looked at an electrode array she was reviewing for calibration.

Her glasses did not need cleaning again.

She cleaned them anyway.

"I would not phrase it that way. You have done good work with bad documentation. The lateral-array drift you flagged two weeks ago is a firmware issue, not a hardware issue. Whoever calibrated him last did the right thing with the wrong tool. The correction is documented in a manual the program never released and that I happen to have memorized. If Kyle ever needs the manual, I can write it out. The work you have done since the last calibration has been creative. *Creative* is the word the program used for what someone did when they did not have access to the documentation but produced the right outcome anyway. It is a compliment. I do not know how to phrase it so that it does not sound condescending. I am sorry for that. I

have spent a lot of years in rooms where the only register I had was the technical one."

Pixel stared at her.

Then Pixel turned to Kyle.

"She is being *gracious* at me," Pixel said, and the word *gracious* was an indictment, "and I cannot find anywhere to land the response. She is too good at this. I am going to need three days to figure out how to be properly angry about this and I do not have three days. Kyle, why is this happening in my building."

"Because the building is also my building," Kyle said.

He meant it as a deflection. It landed as a fact. Pixel registered the fact. The doctor registered Pixel registering the fact. The room re-balanced itself in the small way rooms re-balanced when three people who had not previously been in the same room at the same time decided who was in charge of which silence.

The doctor set her leather case on Kyle's small kitchen table.

"While we are waiting, would you like me to look at the lateral array."

Kyle said: "No."

The doctor nodded.

"That is the correct answer at this time. There is a long answer about why you would benefit from saying yes eventually, and a different long answer about why you should not say yes tonight, and we do not have time for either. I am not going to press. I am going to put the case back in my hand." She picked the case up. She returned to the counter. She did not look at Pixel again, but she did say, in the same level voice: "I would have done good work with what you have. I am glad he has had it. I am leaving in approximately eleven minutes. The arrangement is not permanent. The

work you have been doing is keeping him alive. I would like that to continue."

Pixel did not respond.

Pixel could not respond, because the only response available was gratitude or rage and she would not perform either in front of the doctor, and the doctor knew this, and the doctor was using the knowing the way a researcher used a known variable. Kyle saw Pixel decide to file the encounter for later examination and to exit the room while she still could.

Pixel exited the room. She closed the door behind her.

In the hallway outside 2F, Pixel said — quietly, the way she said things when she did not want them to count as said — "I hate her so much."

Kyle, on the inside of the door, heard her.

He did not respond.

The doctor was at the counter cleaning her glasses again.

The doctor had heard too.

The doctor was pretending she had not.

(Pixel was not wrong. Pixel was also not right. The doctor was what the doctor was, and the doctor had not done anything wrong. Pixel knew this. The hatred was the kind that formed when the world produced a person who was what you would have been if your life had gone differently and they happened to be in your building at four in the morning. The narrator notes this without further comment. File it. Do not act on it. There is not time.)

Sable arrived at 04:28, six minutes earlier than her stated estimate, which was the kind of margin Sable arranged when the math was tight. She came up the back stairs in the tan coat with her hands in the pockets and her ocular implants adjusting to the unit's lighting and her face composed in the precise stillness of a fixer who had decided that the next fifteen minutes were the most expensive fifteen minutes of her quarter.

She did not knock. Kyle had the door open before she reached it. She stepped inside. She looked at the doctor.

"Doctor Park."

"Sable. I have been told to expect you."

"You have been told correctly. We have nineteen minutes to be at Lakeshore Terminal. Pulse 0520 to Rotterdam. From Rotterdam I have a route to a destination I will not name in this room. The destination is reasonable. You will not be comfortable. You will be unfindable."

The doctor nodded. She picked up the leather case. She looked at Kyle.

"Thank you."

Kyle did not say *you are welcome*. He did not have a category for what to say. The hardware did not produce a recommendation. He nodded.

He did not look away from her.

She cleaned her glasses one more time on the hem of her shirt and she followed Sable to the door.

At the door, Sable stopped. She looked back at Kyle.

"Hua is going to know within the hour."

"I know."

"You are going back."

"Yes."

"Why."

Kyle thought about the answer for a half-second.

"Because the contract is the contract. Hua paid me at half. I am going to give her her money back. The contract is going to close from my side because that is the only side it can close from now."

Sable looked at him. The implants made their small adjustment. She did not say *do not go*. She had known him long enough to know that *do not go* was not a sentence he would have heard.

She said: "I will take care of her."

"I know."

The door closed behind them.

The unit was quiet.

The doctor's leather case was gone. The kitchen was the kitchen. The photograph of his mother was on the windowsill facing the intersection. Kyle stood in the middle of the room. The hardware diagnostic resumed its baseline cycle.

Pixel.

He went across the hall and knocked on 2E.

Pixel opened it on the first knock. She had been standing at the door. She had heard Sable arrive and Sable leave. She knew what was coming because she had known what was coming since the moment Kyle had said *this is my safehouse*.

"Don't go," Pixel said.

"I have to."

"You don't."

"I do."

"Kyle. Hua does not require you to bring the money back. The contract was paid at half. If you do not bring the money back, she calls in the half she paid as a debt and it accrues, and you owe her, and that is bad. If you do bring the money back, you are walking into her chamber having just refused her contract, and she puts you in the chair. The chair, Kyle. The actual chair. The one that is bolted to the floor. The one that —" Pixel stopped herself. The breath was shaking in the way her breath shook when she was trying not to perform the shaking. "I have looked at the casualty patterns from every freelancer who has refused a Lotus contract in the last four years. The pattern is the chair. The pattern is hands. The pattern is —"

"Pixel."

"— Kyle. The pattern is *hands*."

"Pixel. I know."

She looked at him. Her face did the thing it did when she was processing — the small flicker of the eyes as the catalogue ran — and then she looked at his hands. He still had them. They were at his sides. The hardware logged Pixel looking at them. He did not move them.

"You know."

"Yes."

"And you are going."

"Yes."

"Why."

"Because the code is the code. Because if I do not close the contract from my side, Hua holds the half-payment as a debt, and the debt sits as ambient leverage that ages without spending, and I will spend the next two years not knowing when she calls it. If I close the contract — refund the money, walk in, walk out — the debt is settled at the cost of whatever she chooses to do

to me when I walk in. The cost will be high. It will not be infinite. The debt would be infinite. I am picking the lower cost."

Pixel closed her eyes.

"You are picking the cost that takes your hands."

"I am picking the cost I can name."

"Kyle."

"Pixel. I know."

She opened her eyes. She looked at him. She did not cry. She had not cried in front of him in three years and she was not going to start now, because the not-crying was part of the convention they had built, and the convention was the only thing keeping either of them upright at this hour. She nodded. The nod was small. The nod was acceptance. The nod was the most expensive nod Pixel had ever given him.

"Come back."

"I will try."

"Try harder than that."

"I will."

She stepped back. She closed the door. He heard the lock cycle. He heard her take three steps away from the door inside the unit and stop. He stood in the hall for two seconds.

Then he went back to 2F.

He picked up Silence from the hook by the kitchen archway. He settled the friction sheath across his back. He picked up the credit chip from the kitchen drawer — the half-payment Hua had given him three hours ago, untouched, the chip still in the evidence sleeve the syndicate banker had put

it in. He put the chip in the inside pocket of the jacket where Hua's manifest sheet lived.

He left 2F. He locked the door. He went down the back stairs.

The rain was still going. Outside the alley, the GLMZ was in the small hours where the city pretended to sleep. Kyle walked south toward the Cruciform Depot. He did not call Sable. He did not call Pixel. He did not call anyone.

The chip was in his pocket. The blade was on his back. The code was the code.

Act 4 — The Refund

The south-arm chamber was exactly as it had been at 01:20 when he had sat down across from Hua and taken the contract.

The crocodile was on the heat rock.

The lamp was at fifteen watts.

The folding chair was bolted to the floor against the far wall.

Hua was at the table reading a different folder this time. She closed it when Kyle stepped through the door. She did not say *sit*.

There were two of her men against the eastern wall now. There had not been at 01:20. Both of them had augmented forearms and the small twitch at the right temple that marked reflex augments at full draw. The senior lieutenant — the one who had been with her twenty years, the one she asked about his mother every Tuesday — was at the door behind Kyle, between Kyle and the only exit.

Kyle's array catalogued all three before his foot had finished the third step into the room.

Kyle took the chip out of his pocket. He walked to the table. He set the chip on the table in front of Hua. He stayed standing.

"Standard rate."

The voice was the voice he had practiced for a long time.

"Refunded."

Hua looked at the chip.

She did not pick it up.

(The arithmetic resolved in his interior, in the silence the chamber had trained itself to hold. The hardware was not the thing doing the arithmetic. The code was doing the arithmetic. The code said:

She picked you because your reputation at extractions of this taxonomy was the only freelance reputation on the roster that meant the entry would solve itself. She did not specify the method. She did not need to. She trusted you to find one. The method you found is your secret. The fact that you found one was hers to count on. That was the capability variable — not the specific hardware she could not have read off your file, but the demonstrated track record, which is the variable any contract designer reads off a roster. That was the reason your name was on the sheet before she opened the folder.

She withheld the cargo's identity because she had read your file. She knew that if the cargo was named, your code would refuse the contract before the door opened. The facility intake would not happen. The doctor would stay where she was. The worst outcome for Hua. So she withheld. The withholding got you through the door. After the door, your choice was the variable.

She designed the contract knowing all three forks served her. Deliver, and the syndicate has the doctor. Refuse, and the doctor is still extracted from the enemy facility, just into someone else's hands; the original threat is still neutralized, and Hua now has cause to take an unaffiliated freelancer's hands and demonstrate Lotus's reach. Die in the extraction, and the doctor is disrupted, the contract written off, the message sent. Every fork served her.

You are now executing a fork she did not model. Refuse, return the money, close the contract from your side. The contract closes properly at her cost. She does not retain the half-payment as ambient debt. She does not get the doctor. She has nothing she can account for except the chair. The chair is no longer the second product on her invoice. The chair is the only product. And the chair as the only product, after a contract she designed to have multiple products, is a smaller win than she budgeted for.

She is going to take the chair anyway. The chair is what is now available to her. Refusing the chair would be admitting the contract failed at her end.

She will not admit that. The chair will happen.

The chair is the cost. The cost is named. The cost is acceptable.)

The arithmetic was complete in 0.6 seconds.

Hua looked up from the chip. She looked at Kyle. She did not smile. She did not frown. She did the thing she did, which was read his face the way she read files. The reading took four seconds. The hardware timed it.

"You returned the money."

"Yes."

"That was not on the form."

"No."

She was quiet for another two seconds. The crocodile breathed. The lamp hummed at the frequency the lamp always hummed at. The two men at the eastern wall did not move. The senior lieutenant at the door behind Kyle did not move either.

Then Hua said, level, the way she had said *Thank you for your time* at the end of every meeting Kyle had ever had with her in this chamber:

"I am going to need to think about that."

She nodded at the senior lieutenant.

The senior lieutenant moved.

He was fast — twenty years of being the senior lieutenant in this chamber had made him fast — and Kyle's array read the motor-bus spike at the lieutenant's forearm 0.3 seconds before the strike came. The array routed the read clean. Kyle's body knew which way to step.

The body did not step.

The body did not step because the body had accepted the cost. The code had accepted the cost. The chair was the cost. The chair was named. Stepping out of the strike would have meant Kyle was now in a room with three armed men and the senior lieutenant and the only exit blocked, and he would have had to fight his way out, and the fighting would have meant he had not actually refunded the contract — he had refunded the chip and then refused the consequence, which was not a refund, which was not the closure of the contract from his side, which was just paperwork.

The code was not paperwork.

Kyle did not step.

The shock-baton hit the chrome bracket in his jaw at exactly the angle the lieutenant had practiced for twenty years to hit it.

Crack.

The pain was a specific frequency, sharp and then radiating. The hardware logged *IMPACT — LEFT MANDIBLE — CHROME BRACKET CONTACT — SEVERITY: SIGNIFICANT*, and the floor came up.

The floor was concrete.

The floor smelled of water that had been in the chamber a long time.

Kyle's left shoulder hit the floor first, then the side of his head, then the rest of him.

The hardware did not lose consciousness — the bio-battery was at fifty-eight percent and the impact had been below the threshold for cardiac shock — but the body was on the floor, and the men were coming around the table, and the chair against the far wall was the chair that had been the chair since before Kyle was born.

Hua was still seated at the table.

She had not stood.

She was not going to stand.

She watched the lieutenant and the two men lift Kyle off the floor and carry him to the chair. She watched them strap his wrists to the bolted arms of the chair with the specific cargo strap the chamber kept in the drawer of the table for exactly this purpose. She watched them check that the straps were at the correct tension.

Then she stood up.

She walked to the small refrigerated cabinet on the eastern wall — the one she kept Iris's food in — and opened it with the key she kept on her person. She took out a wrapped bundle. She closed the cabinet. She walked back to the table.

She set the bundle on the table next to Kyle's chip.

She unwrapped it.

The bundle was a cleaver — heavy, single-edged, the kind of cleaver a butcher used on a side of pork — with a cauterizer band wrapped around the back of the blade. The cauterizer band was the EMT-spec preservation model. The kind that sealed the wound at the same moment it made the cut. The kind that kept the severed thing alive long enough for someone to take it to an AutoDoc.

(The cleaver was made in Solingen, Germany, in 2188, by a knife shop that had been making cleavers for restaurant kitchens since the eighteenth century. The shop had closed in 2215. The cleaver had been imported to the GLMZ by a chef who had brought it with her when she had emigrated from Düsseldorf in 2197 and who had worked in three Wicker restaurants before retiring in 2222 and donating her professional kitchen to a Cantonese co-op who had not wanted the cleaver because the cleaver was the wrong weight for the cuts the co-op did. The cleaver had been sold to a Vultures driver named Lyle for fifteen QUANTA at a yard sale in 2223. Lyle had given the cleaver to Hua in 2224 in payment of a debt Lyle had owed for reasons not on file. Hua had been keeping it in the refrigerated cabinet alongside Iris's food since 2224 because the cabinet was the coldest part of the chamber and

the cleaver was, for Hua, the kind of tool you kept cold. The cauterizer band was newer — Lotus standard issue, fitted in 2225 by the senior lieutenant. The cleaver had been used four times before tonight. Tonight would be the fifth.)

Kyle was in the chair. He was awake. The hardware was awake. The chrome bracket in his jaw was sending a steady ache up the left side of his face. The straps were at the correct tension. The lieutenant was at his right. The two men were at his left.

Hua looked at the cleaver. She looked at Kyle. Her face did not change.

"I am going to do this myself," she said. "I owe you that much."

Kyle did not respond.

There was no response that the convention would accept.

Iris breathed on the heat rock. The lamp hummed. The chamber held.

Hua picked up the cleaver.

(End of chapter five. Chapter six picks up at the cut.)